immediately withdraw across the Tawang Chu and take up a defensive position above Jang and Se-la. In anticipation of getting this plan approved, Palit, as the DMO, had already issued orders stopping the forward movement of additional troops towards Tawang so that the Jang-Tawang route stayed clear for a possible withdrawal.

Thapar, either unable to comprehend the situation, or perhaps simply unable to counter his articulate DMO, failed to act decisively, instead mumbling that he had ‘ordered Bogey Sen’ to be in Tawang and that he would consider the suggestion of a withdrawal the next day.

A few hours later, as Thapar slept in White Gates, on the windswept heights of Bum-la, at 5 a.m. on 23 October, the men in the Assam Rifles post switched off the safety catches on their weapons as they watched three red flares light up the still dark sky. The Chinese mortars and guns then opened up, while RCL guns moved up to blast away the stone sangars behind which the Indians were waiting for the main attack to begin. Two kilometres behind the Assam Rifles position, all the men of 1 Sikh occupying the IB ridge were also looking towards the pass.